

THE EVIDENCE ABOUT

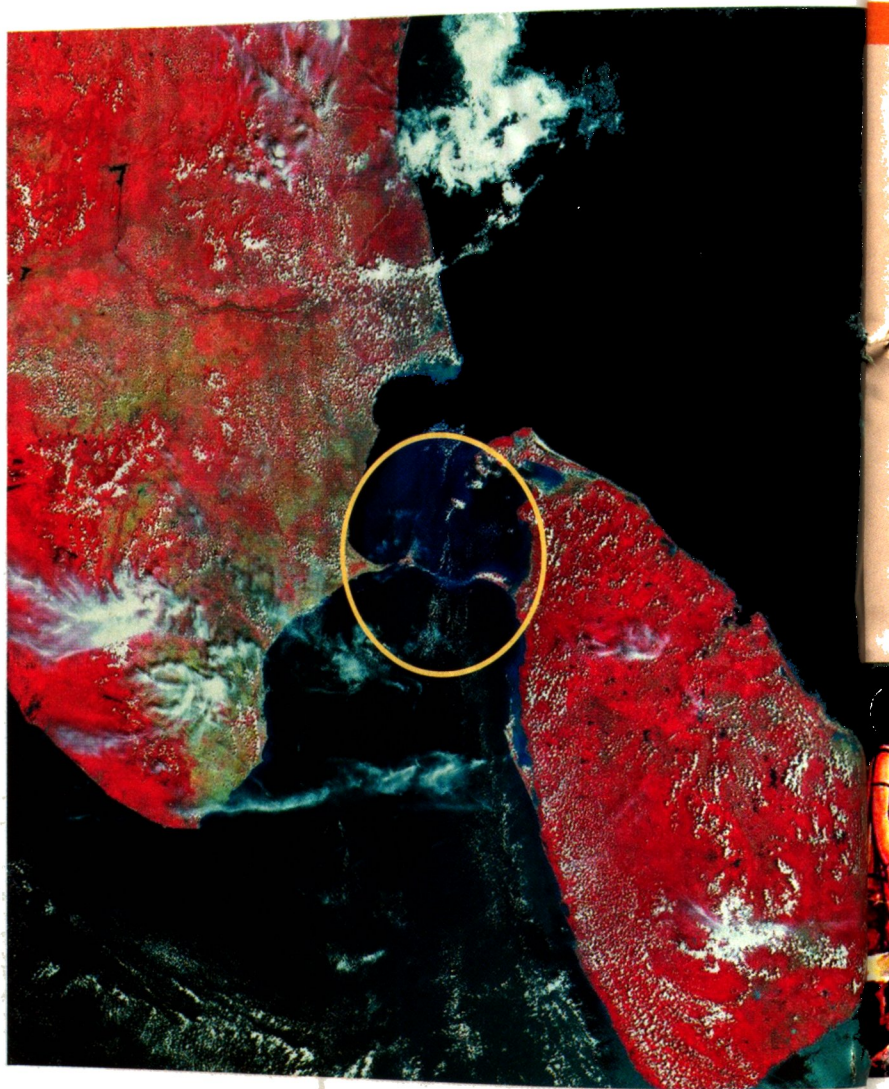
After a Government gaffe, the tide rises on the question of Ram's fabled crossing to Lanka. But finding historical evidence to substantiate the epic may be a bridge too far.

■ By Raj Chengappa

The petitioners, while seeking relief, have primarily relied upon the contents of the Valmiki Ramayana, the Ramcharit-manas by Tulsidas and other mythological texts, which admittedly form an important part of ancient Indian literature, but which cannot be said to be historical record to incontrovertibly prove the existence of the characters or the occurrence of the events therein."

By itself, the paragraph in the affidavit filed by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to the Supreme Court in reply to a writ petition calling for the stoppage of the Sethusamudram Project may not have caused the uproar it subsequently did. After all, for a scientific organisation like ASI, it was stating what it believed to be a matter of fact—that ancient texts cannot "incontrovertibly" prove the existence of Lord Ram and the events that occurred during his lifetime. For, as ASI then went on to pompously state in its affidavit, "the study of human history, which is the primary object of ASI, like other sciences and fields of study, must be carried out in a scientific manner, using available technological aids, and its findings must be based on tangible material evidence".

By submitting such an affidavit, ASI committed a series of major gaffes that deeply embarrassed the UPA Government and gave BJP another potent Ram issue on a platter to politically capitalise on. The Sethusamudram Ship Channel Project was meant to provide a continuous navigation channel between the east and the west coast of India. Currently the pres-



EYE OF THE STORM: Adam's Bridge (above); a painting of Ram Sethu

ence of shallow seas in the area of Adam's Bridge near Rameswaram prevents ships from using the passage, forcing them to sail around Sri Lanka to reach their destination. By dredging parts of the 167-km-long channel at a cost of Rs 2,427 crore, the project hopes to reduce the steaming distance between the two coasts by 780 km and achieve a saving in sailing time of about 30 hours. While the project has been on the anvil for over a century, it gathered momentum only in the past decade and was finally inaugurated in July 2005.

ASI's affidavit, which it subsequently withdrew after the public outcry, was in

reply to a writ petition claiming that Adam's Bridge was the fabled sea bridge that Ram and his supporters built to rescue Sita after Ravana had abducted her to his kingdom in Sri Lanka. The sentiment was bolstered by recent NASA satellite pictures that showed a shoal of rocks seemingly linking Rameswaram with the Sri Lankan coast. In its affidavit, ASI inexplicably failed to recognise that ancient Indian literature about Ram and his epic battle with Ravana was sacred to millions of believers and that it had, over the centuries, deeply influenced generations of Indians. Any reference to the veracity of the texts should have been made with far greater circumspection.